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Warren Vache

Cornetist Warren Vache is the first major player since Ruby Braff to be inspired by the work of Louis Armstrong. Born in Rahway, NJ, in 1951, he first gained acclaim at a Carnegie Hall concert where he recreated the solos of Bix Beiderbecke. Through numerous recordings on Concord Records, he has kept alive and added to the trumpet traditions established by Louis Armstrong, Ruby Braff, and Clifford Brown. He worked frequently with Benny Goodman and Woody Herman and is a familiar figure in jazz events around the country, often in the company of tenor saxist Scott Hamilton.

Warren was interviewed at Hamilton College on September 23, 1995 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: Good afternoon. We are here today filming for the Hamilton Jazz Archive. We have a marvelous concert in store for us this weekend, and part of that is cornetist Warren Vache. Welcome to Hamilton.

WV: Thank you, nice to be here.

MR: Just flew in from New York on a little by-plane and —

WV: Boy are my arms tired.

MR: Yeah, your arms are tired. You are a New York area/New Jerseyite.

WV: I was born in New Jersey I now live in Manhattan, yeah. Most of my life I've kept a residence in that area, sure.

MR: Was being in that area part of — important for your musical upbringing do you think?

WV: I think it was in the sense that when I was a kid it didn't make much difference. But as I started to go to college and began working, I had my first gig at 15, and there was quite a lot of activity around Manhattan and New Jersey and Long Island back then. It meant that I worked almost every weekend of my life from the time I was 15 until now. Unfortunately I didn't do a lot of club hopping when I was a kid, I lived too far away from Manhattan to go in and see that. But later on I was fortunate enough to just catch the end of the club

MR: Heyday —

WV: The club scene, yeah. I mean I worked at Condon's for four years, alongside Vic Dickinson and two or three doors down the street was Jimmy Ryan's and Roy Eldridge was there every night. So I was very fortunate to catch that. And that didn't happen almost anywhere else in the world, you know.

MR: A lot of the fellows we've been talking to who play swing or classic jazz or whatever we want to call it —

WV: What do we want to call it?

MR: I was going to ask you. And we were talking earlier with Ralph Sutton and he refused to call it anything. And I don't know what to call it because it's — I mean swing is a big term, it could mean the big bands but it's also a style of playing. Do you have any thoughts on the kind of music that you like to play?

WV: I think it's part of the problem we have in selling it is that we don't have something we can call it. It's not something that's easily tagged. You draw from so many different inspirations and sources that it's difficult to say I play one particular thing. That means it's hard to sell, it's hard for people who don't know what it is to associate something. You say "swing" it means something different to you than it means to the guy that's pumping your gasoline. We don't have any specific term that really relates anything specific, because the music is this huge thing that encompasses almost all styles and influences.

MR: Yeah, and it's changed pretty quickly in the space of a hundred years, too, from —

WV: Very rapidly.

MR: New Orleans to what we have now. It's interesting that you can still hear almost every phase of jazz being played live, somewhere.

WV: Yeah, one of my favorite expression is "modern jazz is forty years old." These labels don't make much sense to me and I'm sure they don't make sense to the guy on the street, who knows nothing about it. I don't know whether they help or hinder. At this point I'm leaning more towards hindrance.

MR: Well, when you were in your teens, the rock thing was happening, right?

WV: Oh, yeah.

MR: And what led you into this thing? Was it just by virtue of the fact that you played the cornet or the trumpet that you — or did you come from a musical —

WV: I came from a musical family. Dad was a bass player and a part time musician who always worked doing casual jobs, what we used to call club dates, weddings, that sort of thing. He had a large record collection, and played records. One of my fondest memories as a kid is being able to wake up and lay in bed and listen to music for an hour. You know, it just was there. It was always around me. And Dad had a magnificent collection of 78s which he didn't mind, you know, an eight or a nine year old going through and playing for himself. So these things were interesting, and I was interested in it. The reason I never really gravitated toward rock & roll was in part a snobishness on my part because I didn't think it as interesting as the stuff I was listening to. And also in part it was not as interesting. I mean I still can't take the Beach Boys as seriously as I can take Louis Armstrong, you know, or for that matter even Ray Noble, guys that were serious musicians. There was a lot of deep intent and thought put into music, and I didn't find that in rock & roll.

MR: Was one of your first big moments — this is something I read and I don't know if it's true — you did a concert with the New York Jazz Repertory and you were doing some Bix tunes or something?

WV: Yeah, that was the first concert I really did in New York was for the New York Jazz Repertory Company, and it was the music of Bix Beiderbecke and thanks to Bucky Pizzarelli and Kenny Davern, and some very timely recommendations, I was cast as Bix for a day.

MR: Did you do a lot of listening before that, or was it already a part of you?

WV: I don't — I mean I've been listening to you know those Beiderbecke records since I was a kid. I knew most of the stuff from having played it millions of times, just as I knew a lot of Louis Armstrong solos from having played it a hundred and — you know, a little kid with a trumpet and you hear somebody do something like "West End Blues" — it's still pretty astounding. Even now, I've played the trumpet for forty years, and every time I hear "West End Blues" I think it's astounding. So yeah, I was prepared that way, and of course Bob Wilber or somebody had done note for note transcriptions, so it was not a question of having to transcribe it myself, but rather just interpret.

MR: He was an interesting character I guess, from what I read.

WV: Bix? Well one of the interesting things about that series of concerts was that they had everybody that was still alive from the Goldkette band involved in that concert at one time or another, so while I never met Bix, I hung out with Joe Venuti, I hung out with Doc Ryker who was the lead alto saxophone, Chauncey Morehouse the drummer was still alive, Spiegle Willcox, who may be here tomorrow, is still alive living in Cincinnatus, New York. You ought to go over and see him.

MR: My goodness, thanks for that information.

WV: Oh, he's a pistol, too. He's just absolutely as bright as a tack. He was in the Goldkette band with all those guys. But everybody that had anything to do with the Goldkette band was at one point or other part of that series of concerts. And I've always — I have a sense of history that gives me a great deal of pleasure when I get to meet and interact with people that have experienced something.

MR: I know what you mean. This has been like that for us.

WV: That I've only read about. And my experience in the music business as been full of those things. Where else could a nineteen year old C student from New Jersey sit alongside Vic Dickinson and take a master class for four years?

MR: That's the great, probably the most effective way of learning is absorbing that on the spot.

WV: Oh, yeah, I mean there was Vic to work with and I'd wait until about eleven o'clock because it took Roy just about that long to warm up, and then I'd walk into Ryan's and

buy a beer, and Roy had the most competitive, wonderful nature of anyone I'd ever met. Any other trumpet player was a call to arms. So he'd look out in the bar and see the competition in there. And the roof would go off the joint. And I mean I'd get to watch — not only do you get to listen to Roy play — playing is one thing — you get to watch the way guys lead the band, the way they interact with the people, the way they run the room, because that's essentially what you're doing. You know, you can't, I never did think that you could stand up on the stage with your eyes closed and really fully communicate with people. In that situation, Roy was absolutely magnificent. He just had everybody engaged and kept them that way, and entertained the hell out of them.

MR: He couldn't resist a challenge I guess.

WV: Well I mean he used to make that, but that was, there's another thing I'd like to address. I mean Roy was always, always up for a challenge, always would put you in the situation of a challenge. And somehow, when he beat you, you never felt put down, it was an honor. A quick story is one night I think we got done at Condon's early. It might have been about one o'clock in the morning, and I was across the street getting in my car to go home. And I see Roy coming out of Ryan's, running across the street. He says, "Where you going?" I said, "Well they let us out early, I'm going to go home." He says, "Oh man, you've got to come help me on the last set." All right, Roy Eldridge is asking me to come help? Sure I'll be there. I must have had a neon sign on my forehead that said "sucker." I walked into the club, he bought me a drink, we went up to play the last set, Roy calls a tune, we play the first chorus, and he points at me to take the first solo. So I played a couple of choruses. And he looked at me with a twinkle in his eye and said, "Came to get me, huh?" He picked the trumpet up in his left hand, played five choruses, no note under high C, his right hand in the jacket pocket swinging it back and forth on two and four. Shot me, dug the hole, put me in the box, put the box in the ground, stomped on the dirt, and looked at me and smiled. Now I walked out of there feeling absolutely wonderful. I'd had a lesson, you know, I mean I couldn't get mad at this guy are you kidding? It was a magnificent thing to me. A lot of the feeling I get from the contemporary crop of musicians is more competitive and less camaraderie than that. I mean if you told me tomorrow that Roy Eldridge would do the same thing to me, I'd be there waiting in line. It was magnificent.

MR: That's great. The stories I've read about that kind of thing in Kansas City and that all night jam session. It's such a great learning experience and I don't know if it's still happening these days.

WV: Well there was a lot of competition, but I think it was a little less intense and there was a lot more camaraderie.

MR: Tell us how you moved out of the, more on to the national scene from the New York area, and did you have a couple of big breaks along the way or was it a gradual —

WV: I was just very fortunate in being in the right place at the right time in a lot of instances. Right after the Bix Beiderbecke concert, Benny Goodman was looking for a trumpet player. And again, Bucky Pizzarelli recommended me. John Bunch recommended me. And the next thing I knew I found myself on a plane going somewhere in New Hampshire to play with Benny Goodman. No rehearsal, no nothing.

MR: With a small group?

WV: I was out working on my car. I was draining the oil from my little Fiat. My old man comes out and says, "It's the phone for you." And I went in and said, "Hello?" And the voice said, "This is Benny." Of course I said, "Benny who?" I couldn't believe it was Benny Goodman. Benny Goodman called me personally. Bang — I was up there, and for the next ten years or so on and off, I worked with Benny Goodman off and on in varying combinations.

MR: Great.

WV: It was interesting. It was also scarier than hell.

MR: That's what most people say.

WV: I went through a lot of underwear. It was a scary period. Because I really didn't — I knew I didn't have the, all the knowledge, and all the confidence necessary to be in that level. You turn around, I was like 21, 22, and Hank Jones was playing piano, Slam Stewart's playing bass, Connie Kay's playing drums, Zoot Sims, Urbie Green, Benny Goodman and me?

MR: Had he heard you play at that point? Maybe on a record?

WV: I don't believe so. No I hadn't recorded — up to that point I don't think I'd made a recording. He just simply took Bucky's recommendation, and just kept me on for about ten years. Of course I had to be a pretty quick study. But again, there was no music.

MR: I was just going to ask about arrangements.

WV: The kind of arrangements we did with the small band were pretty much made up on the spot, and what note you had pretty much depended on who was the other sideman for that week. That's one of the experienced I had growing up that kids don't get nowadays. Even the club date bands that I started to play with when I was in high school and college. I mean there were guys around New York that would hire you for a society wedding or a dance at the Westchester Country Club. And you'd show up and there'd be three saxophones, two trumpets and a trombone, and three rhythm, and these guys would eat the songs. They'd get a tempo and play a dance medley that lasted twenty minutes, no more than one chorus of any tune. Medleys. Twenty minutes of medleys. No only did they play all those, I mean they eat up five hundred tunes a set. And they would play it in

three part and six part harmony, the melody would bounce back and forth between the brass and the saxophones, all with little hand signals that went on. And you had to use your ear. You had to sit there, and if the first trumpet was playing the lead, the trombone had the fifth, you had to play the third. I mean there was an understood first and second and third part harmony. And you learn a lot, having to think on your feet. Not only do you learn the tunes, you learn the harmony, you learn to sort of intuit where the change is going to go. I mean that was wonderful training ground.

MR: Right, and it's really hard to teach that in a classroom.

WV: I don't think it can be done. I don't think it can be done because of the immediacy, that not having time to think. You know I've got to tell you there's an awful lot of bad notes that go by too. But you learn that bad notes are not always the worst thing in the world, as long as you keep your eye on the intent.

MR: And play them in time.

WV: Play them in time, and correct it the next time it comes along. So that's essentially what I had to do with Benny except that the rhythm sections were better and the band swung more.

MR: Did you get to go overseas with him?

WV: Yeah, I did my first overseas trip in 1974 with Benny and John Bunch and Bucky Pizzarelli, Barrett Deems, and I think Urbie was on that one, Peter Appleyard on vibes.

MR: Tell us about your association with Scott Hamilton and how that came about.

WV: Well, I was working at Condon's at the time and the fellow that worked the door and sort of managed the place, used to run the Half Note, Mike Cantarino was his name. And Mike was running — the Condon band worked Tuesday through Saturday, and on Sundays Mike would book another band. And Mike had heard Scott play with Hank Jones over at Michael's Pub and thought it would be a good idea since we were more or less the same age, to put us together for a Sunday night there, which is where I met him. We've just continued the relationship for a long time.

MR: It's a good match. You guys are playing a kind of music we mentioned earlier, that we don't know what to call it. But it comes from a time that was before your formative years I guess. What's the most modern type situation you've ever found yourself in? Is that a fair term? Or contemporary —

WV: What are you talking about? See I can intuit what I think you mean.

MR: I guess I'm talking about if you've found yourself in situations with electronic instruments.

WV: Yeah, sure.

MR: And do you like those more? Is it just something different?

WV: My problem with electronic instruments is that they have one color and that's the color you're stuck with. The player really has very little aside from flipping switches and adjusting sliders, there's nothing you can do physically, touching the instrument, to make the sound different. I mean a synthesizer is going to make Dave McKenna sound like everybody else that touches a synthesizer. Whereas you put him at a piano it can only be Dave McKenna. So there's a little more richness for me in Dave's personality. Electronic instruments seem, for me, they seem to handicap personal expression. Now when you're playing over them, sometimes it can be a lot of fun. Because I mean synthesizers are nice and warm and they're cheap. And it's nice to play over that sort of cushion. If you're talking about different harmonic situations, one of the things about the music I play generally, and have a great love for, is that it's pretty standard harmonies. It's not necessarily modal. It's two fives and melodies. There are different sorts of harmonic, the modal school, I've played with that. But I don't sort of find, again, it's a matter of expression. I think there's a greater breadth of emotion to be expressed in chromatic harmony than there is in modal harmony. Modal is different, you don't get that in chromatic harmony, it is different. But I don't find the same subtlety within the framework that I do in chromatic music. I have yet to hear a modal piece of music that had the same sort of richness of color as a Brahms symphony, or for that matter a nice Clifford Brown solo. It pulls me in many directions.

MR: It seems like sometimes with modal based music too, they seem to spend longer on each change perhaps and I don't know if sometimes that's a good thing.

WV: Well all I know is I went in, I had some trouble with my back and I went to a chiropractor one time. I'm lying on this table while he's got these electrodes stimulating a muscle or something, charging me too much money. And he's got a radio station on, and it's this New Age stuff. And I spent a half an hour lying on that table listening to the lydian mode in F. It must have been about fifteen selections, and they were all in the God damn lydian mode in F. By the time he got back I said, "Are you trying to relax my muscles or give me a lobotomy?" Change the station. I mean I don't understand it's like just blah — this thing that says okay I'm calm, I'm relaxed, I'm hip. Now can I feel something? That's exactly what happens, you know. I'd much rather listen to Louis Armstrong playing ski dat de dat.

MR: What led you — I'm going to turn back the clock a little bit — what led you to stick with the cornet? Is there any special reason for that?

WV: Yeah, well, the other part of what I got from being around guys like Roy and Vic was that controlling your instrument and learning to play it well are only the beginning phase of being a musician. The sound that instrument makes has to become your voice, as natural as when you speak or sing. And just as idiomatic as the singing or speaking voice is,

that's what your sound on the instrument is allowed to become in jazz. So the reason I play the cornet is because that's what I hear, that is my voice. I've had 150 trumpets in my hand. They never feel as comfortable as a cornet does. Now I'm admittedly not looking to get work in studios where I'm going to make the sound the producer wants to hear. When you make this choice, you actually limit the sort of work you can take. I'm not going to go out and audition for the Hamilton College Symphony, because the sound I make is going to be unacceptable in that situation. But you make that decision. And part of the magic of jazz for me is that so much of a player's personality is expressed in that sound. You hear Vic Dickinson, there's never going to be another person in the world that's going to make that sound. Truly and completely unique. I can hear two bars of Roy Eldridge and tell you who it is. I mean this is the sort of thing that really fascinated me and I think that my life is just a constant search to find where I am — in relation to what I've learned, what I know, where I've worked — to find that voice, that character that makes me unique.

MR: Well you really echo the sentiments of some of the other fellows we've talked to, Al Grey and Sweets Edison, they said the same thing in different ways.

WV: You talked to Sweets Edison?

MR: Yes.

WV: Did you get enough that you didn't have to edit? He's the funniest man in the world. I have to send him $65 a month, you know, because I steal so much of his stuff.

MR: He said the same thing: he said that he doesn't hear, well he wasn't complaining. He said that today he doesn't hear that striving for sound as much as when he was coming on, and that that was a big part of everyone's goal.

WV: Yeah. Strength for individuality. Now everybody has a lovely, schooled, technical, marvelous approach, and I can't distinguish one of them from another. You got three notes of Sweets, I mean Sweets Edison invented himself. He's one of the prime characters in America and always has been. I mean it's funny, where the hell was I, I did some jazz party and they put a bunch of trumpet players on the stand and Sweets was with us. And we're all up there sweating and popping veins and doing our level best to impress everybody, and Sweets comes up and goes "boop" and the audience melts. It's like shooting fish in a barrel for him. You know he doesn't even have to touch it, he's just so unique that I mean that's the sort of thing that really, one of these days, I'll get there. That's what I'm working for, you know?

MR: How has the music scene changed for you or has it, since you started? Is it — for our aspiring jazz musicians — is it getting tougher?

WV: Yeah, I feel very sorry for anybody that really wants to start it now. What's gone, what's not necessarily gone, I'm starting to sound like my father for heaven's sake. What's not

the same is that there are fewer and fewer places to play and earn while you learn. Those club dates that I did, all the little clubs that I used to go and work on a Saturday night, the places I used to go sit in, they're gone. I mean it's not to say they won't come back at some point, but that whole — there used to be so much to do. I could work three or four times a week in New York doing receptions for companies, and they all had a live band. And now you get one guy with a synthesizer and a singer.

MR: Or a DJ.

WV: Or a DJ. And that part of it's gone. There's a lot of bread and butter work that isn't there anymore. And that means that all that's happened is that it's been polarized. You're either making a lot of money, or you've got a day job and you do it for fun, because economically it's a struggle to stay just in the middle, to just make a living. Now there's less studio work because the electronics have taken over. You laughed when I said the synth is cheaper, but it's a major impact on what we do. Sit down with a pencil sometime when you're watching television at night, and let those commercials go by. Just make a tick every time you hear electronic background and a tick every time you hear a real live music. You are going to find that electronics is getting a lot of the work.

MR: Oh, yeah, even in the pit bands for the touring Broadway shows I've seen, you know, now they've got six or seven people in the pit and they're playing, the string section is now a keyboard man. Things change.

WV: Something, I mean it's a question of taste too. This is an art, and we sell it to people, and as a result it's, we're at the mercy of public taste, whichever way it goes. And you can blame marketers for influencing public taste. And sometimes you're in the right spot and the right time, and sometimes you're not, you know? I don't know quite, if anyone has any control over that.

MR: Well, we don't want to get too down. Let's, tell me about one of the greatest gigs you ever had, or is it maybe tonight?

WV: The next one.

MR: The next one.

WV: The next one. I think all in all for me the most exciting time of my life was Condon's and being next to Gene. I mean thousands of people used to come hang at that bar. It was a party every night and most of the musicians that I heard about, read about, respected and many that I didn't know came in and it was the time of my life where I actually met all of my heroes in a working capacity. It was a marvelous time. I didn't know it at the time, but looking back on it now it was one hell of a good time.

MR: Yeah. Tell us what a typical month for you is like now — a lot of traveling I would imagine, to get— I mean there's probably not that many engagements right where you live.

WV: I don't think I've worked in New York in the last six years.

MR: Wow. So it's —

WV: I'm on the road six to eight months a year. It's a lot of traveling, a lot of flying. A typical month is basically spending a lot of time on the telephone trying to fill in holes in the calendar for the next month. I don't very often get to control who I play with, but through these years I've developed a system of very dear friends, I don't have an agent, so these friends will —

MR: I was going to ask, so you handle your own business?

WV: Well, yeah. I'm looking for somebody but it's one of those catch-22 situations where you don't make enough money without an agent to warrant an agent. You know I just am going to crack that wall one of these days. Well so far I've managed to make a fairly decent living and I do what I like to do so there's a certain, I mean, I won't be driving the Cadillac this year, I won't be retiring at age 50, but I get to do what I like.

MR: Ralph Sutton has an attitude that's quite like that, and he seems to say I'm not going to do anything I don't want to do. And I said, gee, that's nice.

WV: Well Ralph is in a situation and at a stage in his life where he can say that. Now I'm supporting a fourteen year old and an eight year old, an ex-wife, and myself. So much as I would like to say I'm not going to do anything I don't want to do, very often the reality is get me something to do, you know?

MR: It's interesting to go into these jazz parties and cruises and so forth that, like you said, you don't have much control over who you're going to play with. And the idea of having a repertory of tunes in your head I think is imposing to students who think about, well I know *The Real Book* or I know every sixth page of *The Real Book* or something. But you really have to have a pretty vast songlist in your head I would think, because you get into situations and —

WV: You have to be able to think on your feet very quickly. I mean I'll take a tour in England, I don't know who I'm going to work with. And I could end up playing somewhere in the middle of the country with a pianist I've never seen before, who only knows — I've got to be able to look at this guy and figure what he's going to know. And if I call a tune that he doesn't know, I have to have another one immediately ready. Because I'm entertaining a roomful of people, I have to do this with a guy I've never met before. You have to find a way to keep everybody engaged, and this guy engaged. And sometimes it gets pretty tough. But you develop chops for it.

MR: Right, chops, and your mental chops.

WV: You walk on the stage prepared to think on your feet. And if that involves playing "Watermelon Man" all night long, that's what you're going to have to do. You may not be happy about it, but it's got to be done.

MR: Wow. Who are the guys — who is your dream band? Can you tell me about that?

WV: No.

MR: Too many guys?

WV: Just too many, yeah. I just love so many people.

MR: Have you worked behind some notable singers over the years?

WV: Well, Rosemary Clooney. Scott and I did Rosemary Clooney for a number of years. I just did a record with Bobby Short, and a double album with Benny Carter that is "The Benny Carter Songbook" and has oh I would think anywhere from twelve to thirteen singers on it. Everyone did two or three tracks apiece or one track apiece. Everybody from Shirley Horn to Joe Williams.

MR: Interesting. If you had one word of advice for our aspiring musicians, how to practice? Spend half your time practicing — something. Is there something you could fill in there?

WV: Well let's see. From the point of view of practicing as a trumpet player, we're all concerned with endurance. Because it hurts to play the instrument. What I did was when it started to hurt I put the horn down. So instead of practicing an hour and a half at a clip, I may do thirty minutes three times a day, or fifteen minutes six times a day. But if it starts to hurt, stop, because you're practicing at feeling bad. You might as well practice while it feels good. If your lip isn't working, don't struggle. Put it back down. The other one is an amazing amount of practice for me, this is not the physicality of the instrument, but an amazing amount of practice for me happens all day long. I'm always thinking about music. At this point in my life, every time I hear a tone I've got fingers going down, because that's what I've done naturally, you know? So there's a larger sort of practicing if you're really committed to music, every time you hear a piece of music there's a certain amount of analysis that gets done. For instance, if something moves you on something you've heard on the radio, can you analyze what the voicing was that moved you? Can you analyze, do you know what the chord was? If you don't have perfect pitch, do you sit there and try to figure out well that's an A minor seven and the seventh is in the bass and that's why it's that movement that I like. And you remember that and use it somewhere else. And that's, I mean this is the great vast wonderful thing about music is the more you know the more you know you don't know and the more there is to find and hear. So in that sense the practicing never stops. Because just learning to play and make a sound on an instrument is not enough. That's not what it's about. It's about making music, and that involves thought, a lot of which is compulsive in me. I've always said that anybody that goes into music or into jazz for a living does it because they're diseased. It's a compulsion, you know. It's a disease. There's a voice in my head that keeps playing melodies. I can't stop it, much as I'd like to sometimes.

MR: I don't think there's any medication for that either.

WV: I don't think so either. It's a disease, we're stuck.

MR: Well, on that note, we're looking forward to the concert tonight, and thanks for sharing your thoughts with us.

WV: My pleasure, Monk, thanks for having me.

MR: On behalf of the Hamilton Jazz Archive, I'd like to thank Warren Vache for his time, and we'll see you tonight.

WV: Good. I'll go home and practice.

MR: Fifteen minutes only.

WV: That's it, you got it.